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tonnes in the second, says the council.

Vivek Ramabhadran, who ran Swarovski's crystals business in India and South Asia before founding the jewellery brand Aulerth, says jewellery has become a lifestyle expression. "It's not about what I will hand over to my daughter and keep in a locker for 20 years but something I want to wear regularly," he says. Because people "still place a huge premium on buying gold", they are "willing to reduce the quantum (size) of what they wear." That means demand for simple pendants, lighter pieces, nine-karat in place of 22-karat, and lab-grown diamonds, more than 90% of which are set in gold. "Rationally, what's the investment value of nine-karat gold? Probably nothing," he says. "But culturally it's still gold. And that matters for India."

With gold prices still high, retailers and experts expect this trend of buying lighter and smarter to continue beyond the festive season.

Ramabhadran's own customers, mostly women aged 35 to 65 who already own plenty of gold, have gone further. For them, buying gold for variety "stopped making sense long back", he says. "In gold, you don't get the kind of variety that you get in fashion jewellery." So, they buy design-led pieces that have no intrinsic metal value.

Jewellery remains luxury's strongest category this year, according to Bain-Altagamma's June update. In 2025, sales grew 4–6% to about €32 billion. In India, jewellery and watches had the largest share of affluent buyers spending more than ₹2 lakh a year, says the Atlas of Affluence.

In watches, too, India appears to be a standout. Swiss watch exports to India rose 31.7% to 231.9 mil-